> What would be your attitude, Mr. President, had something like this happened with respect to the United States? I believe your assessment of the intentions of the other side would have been under the circumstances only one with respect to that other side's approach to negotiations, as well as the substance of its intentions. Even under these circumstances we have displayed utmost restraint. And the response measures we were forced to take as far as their scope and character are concerned, have not gone beyond the limits necessary to neutralize the threat created for us and our allies.

Chernenko went on to write that it was conceivable that our countries might increase cooperation at some levels, but no significant progress on arms control was possible as long as NATO continued deploying the new missiles or the United States continued work on the Strategic Defense Initiative. He also said that the United States had no business raising human rights issues involving the Soviet Union.

> I must point out that the introduction into relations between our two states of solely domestic affairs of our or your country does not serve the purpose of improving these relations if this is our goal. I wish that questions of such nature do not burden our correspondence. . . .

After reading Chernenko's letter, I remarked in the diary: "They are going to be cold and stiff necked for awhile. But we must not become supplicants. We're trying to get agreement on a few lesser matters."

A few weeks later, we got an even plainer signal from the Russians that they weren't in a hurry to improve relations when they announced they were going to boycott the